

Data-Model Hybrid Learning for Single Image Super Resolution

Weihong Guo, Ying Liang, Yifei Lou, Jing Qin, Max Van Fleet, Pavi Venkatachalapathy, Chuxiangbo Wang, Min Wang

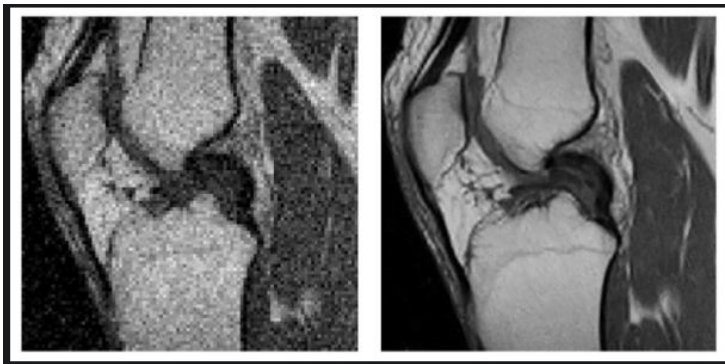
August 6, 2026

- Introduction of SISR
- Regularized Activation Functions
- Deep Image Prior
- Diffusion Model Performance and Its Variants
- Things We Have Tried: Adding regularity to different frameworks and in different parts (encoder, decoder, loss...)
- Future Work: DIP+Diffusion with spatial regularity, more problem adaptive priors

Single Image Super Resolution

LR: $\mathbf{y} \in \mathcal{R}^{m \times n \times p}$, HR: $\mathbf{x} \in \mathcal{R}^{M \times N \times P}$

$$\mathbf{y} = D(\mathbf{x}) + \epsilon$$



$$\text{ReLU}(x) = \begin{cases} 0 & \text{if } x < 0 \\ x & \text{if } x \geq 0 \end{cases}$$

$$\text{ReLU}(x) = \operatorname{argmin}_{y \geq 0} \|x - y\|^2$$

We define the **STD-regularized ReLU** as:

$$\text{ReLU}_{STD}(x) = \operatorname{argmin}_{y \geq 0} \|x - y\|^2 + \lambda \langle y, K_\sigma * (1 - y) \rangle$$

Linearization of the STD Term:

$$R(y) \approx R(y^t) + \langle P(y^t), y - y^t \rangle, \quad \text{where } P(y^t) = K_\sigma * (1 - 2y^t) \in \partial R(y^t)$$

The full objective becomes:

$$\operatorname{argmin}_{y \geq 0} \|x - y\|^2 + \lambda \langle P(y^t), y \rangle$$

Thus, iterate $\text{ReLU}_{STD}(x) = \text{ReLU}(x - \lambda P(y^t))$

STD Regularized Leaky ReLU

$$\text{LeakyReLU}(x) = \begin{cases} \alpha x & \text{if } x < 0 \\ x & \text{if } x \geq 0 \end{cases}$$

$$\text{LeakyReLU}(x) = \arg \min_y \left\{ \frac{1}{2} \|x - y\|^2 + \frac{1 - \alpha}{2\alpha} \cdot \|\min(y, 0)\|^2 \right\}$$

We define the **STD-regularized Leaky ReLU** as:

$$\begin{aligned} \text{LReLU}_{\text{STD}}(x) = \arg \min_y \left\{ \frac{1}{2} \|x - y\|^2 + \frac{1 - \alpha}{2\alpha} \cdot \|\min(y, 0)\|^2 \right. \\ \left. + \lambda \langle y, K_{\sigma} * (1 - y) \rangle \right\} \end{aligned}$$

Linearized Objective:

$$\min_y \left\{ \frac{1}{2} \|y - x\|^2 + \frac{1 - \alpha}{2\alpha} \cdot \|\min(y, 0)\|^2 + \lambda \langle P(y^t), y \rangle \right\}$$

Deep Image Prior (DIP)¹

They interpreted neural network as a parameterization of the image $x = f_{\theta}(z)$, where f denotes a network with its parameter θ (to be optimized) and z is a (fixed) vector of the same dimension as x .

Given the network architecture f , the parameter θ can be optimized via

$$\theta^* = \arg \min_{\theta} E(f_{\theta}(z); y) \Rightarrow x^* = f_{\theta^*}(z),$$

where E is a task-dependent data fidelity term and y is the degraded input.

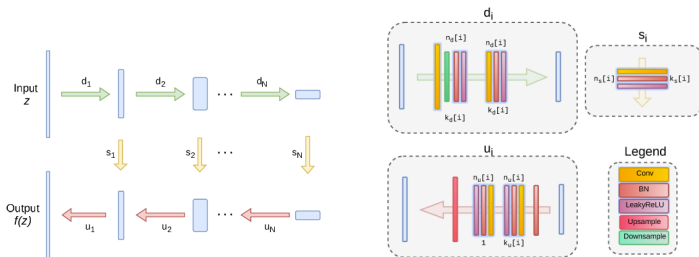
Specifically, for super-resolution, we consider the following model

$$E(x; y) = \|DBx - y\|_2^2,$$

where B is a blurring operator and D is a downsampling operator.

¹Dmitry Ulyanov et al., CVPR, 2018

DIP rationales



- The network f_θ can capture some of the *low-level statistics* of natural images.
- The neural network reconstructs the clean image before converging to the corresponding degraded input, and consequently, an early stopping condition is desirable.

Motivation for STD Regularized DIP

- DIP does not fully consider the image characteristics, e.g., piecewise smoothness and edges.
- Embed STD regularized activation functions into the DIP architecture.

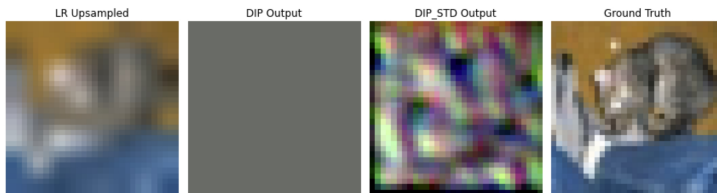


Figure: A toy DIP with 2 hidden layers, ReLu and STDReLu in the last layer.

- A limitation of DIP is that it processes only a single image. We aim to address this by integrating DIP with diffusion models.

Diffusion based SR

- DDPM (denoising diffusion probabilistic models)

- Forward:**

$$q(\mathbf{z}_t | \mathbf{z}_{t-1}) = \mathcal{N}(\mathbf{z}_t | \sqrt{1 - \alpha_t} \mathbf{z}_{t-1}, \alpha_t I) \quad (1)$$

Here, α_t are schedules of adding noise, $\gamma_t = \prod_{i=1}^t (1 - \alpha_i)$

$$q(\mathbf{z}_0) \approx q(\text{HR images}) \quad (2)$$

- Backward:**

$$q(\mathbf{z}_T) \approx \mathcal{N}(0, 1) \quad (3)$$

$$p_\theta(\mathbf{z}_{t-1} | \mathbf{z}_t, \mathbf{x}) = \mathcal{N}(\mathbf{z}_{t-1} | \mu_\theta(\mathbf{z}_t, \gamma_t, \mathbf{x}), \Sigma_\theta(\mathbf{z}_t, \gamma_t, \mathbf{x})) \quad (4)$$

which conditioned on LR image $\mathbf{x}$.

- Loss**

$$KL(q(\mathbf{z}_0, \dots, \mathbf{z}_T) || p_\theta(\mathbf{z}_0, \dots, \mathbf{z}_T)) \geq \mathbb{E}[-\log p_\theta(\mathbf{z}_0)] + c$$

$$\mathcal{L}_{DDPM}(\epsilon_\theta) := \mathbb{E}_{\substack{t \sim \mathcal{U}(1, T) \\ \mathbf{z}_0 \sim q(\mathbf{z}_0) \\ \epsilon \sim \mathcal{N}(\mathbf{0}, I)}} [\lambda(t) || \epsilon - \epsilon_\theta(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{z}_t, \gamma_t) ||^2] \quad (5)$$

- Smooth Total Variation Loss — (differentiable version)

$$\mathcal{L}_{TV}(\mathbf{z}) = TV(u) = \sqrt{\sum_{i,j} (\mathbf{z}_{i+1,j} - \mathbf{z}_{i,j})^2 + (\mathbf{z}_{i,j+1} - \mathbf{z}_{i,j})^2} + \epsilon_{tv} \quad (6)$$

- Total loss

$$\begin{aligned} \mathcal{L}(\theta) &= \mathcal{L}_{DDPM}(\epsilon_\theta) + \beta \mathcal{L}_{TV}(\hat{\mathbf{z}}_{0,\theta}) \\ \hat{\mathbf{z}}_{0,\theta} &:= \frac{1}{\gamma_t} [\mathbf{z}_t - \sqrt{1 - \gamma_t} \epsilon_\theta(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{z}_t, \gamma_t)] \end{aligned} \quad (7)$$

Preliminary Results

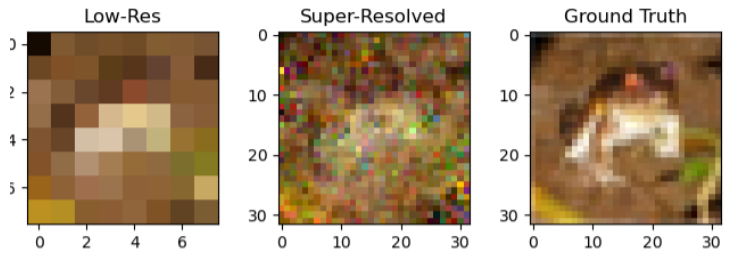


Figure: STDDRelu+TV

	Standard DDPM	DDPM+TV	DDPM + STDDRelu	DDPM + STDDRelu +STDDRelu+TV
PSNR	14.9238	16.2325	15.2827	16.3871
SSIM	0.2328	0.2057	0.1708	0.2164

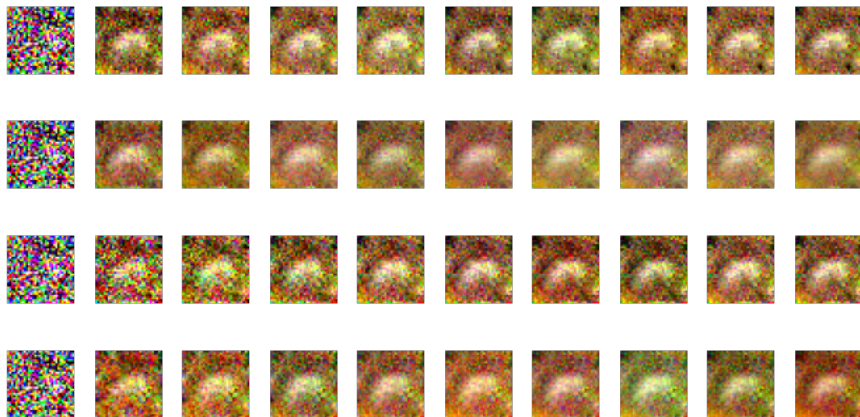
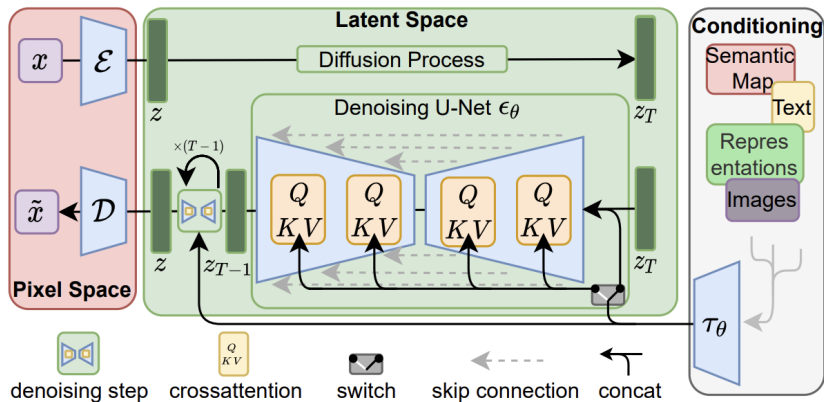


Figure: Denoising process v.s. epoch. Top Row: Standard DDPM; Second Row : DDPM+Total Variations; Third Row : DDPM+STDReLu; Bottom Row : DDPM+STDReLu+TV.

Latent diffusion model rationales



Unet leaky ReLU and STD leaky ReLU comparison

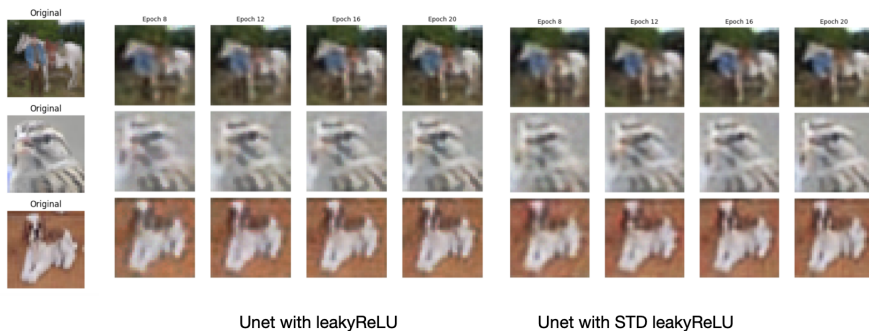


Figure: VAE reconstruction v.s. epochs for leaky ReLU and STD leaky ReLU as activation function

Loss for leaky ReLU: 37.0814

Loss for STD leaky ReLU: 34.7861

• DIP

- Implemented Image Super-Resolution using Deep Image Prior (DIP)
- Used a randomly initialized CNN to reconstruct a high-resolution image from low-resolution input via implicit priors
- Trained for 4000 iterations with LeakyReLU activation function for factor 8.

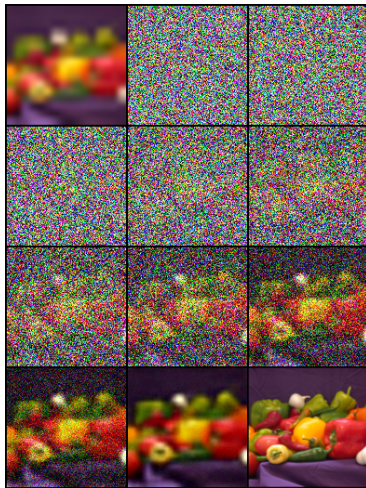
• SR3

- Implemented Image Super Resolution via Iterative Refinement (SR3)
- Adapted the code from Liangwei Jang²
- Trained on CIFAR-10³ data set (60k images) and tested on peppers image
- 2000 diffusion time steps

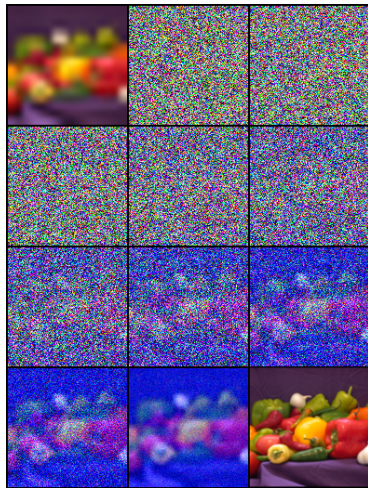
²<https://github.com/Janspiry/Image-Super-Resolution-via-Iterative-Refinement>

³A. Krizhevsky, G. Hinton, "Learning multiple layers of features from tiny images," University of Toronto, Tech. Rep., 2009.

SR3 Progression



50k Iterations



100k Iterations

Figure: SR3 progression snapshots

Preliminary Results



	SR3 (50k)	SR3 (100k)	SR3 (Pre-trained 640k)	SR3 leaky (10k)	DIP
PSNR	14.888	9.3052	17.072	9.3704	26.59
SSIM	0.33269	0.186	0.42931	0.18718	0.959

Future Work I: Regularized Diffusion Models

- Add regularization about the image to be recovered in the training loss to learn a better diffusion model.
- Study the DIP regularized with STD in the diffusion model.
- Adapt the regularized diffusion method to a state-of-the-art backbone architecture, e.g., SR3, and compare with other methods.

Future Work II: STD Regularized DIP+SR3

- 1 Build a DIP network (with STDReLU) to hallucinate a HR image that downscales to the input LR image
- 2 Sample noise and forward/backward steps using the diffusion process
- 3 Use DIP to generate a clean HR image from random noise
- 4 Feed DIP output to the diffusion model, e.g., SR3, to refine it conditioned on the LR image
- 5 Evaluate the quality of the recovered image via PSNR and SSIM